

Face-2-Face with Employer

“If you were to look at an invention as a plot of land, then patents is the boundary wall of this innovation. We have seen claims written so badly that they don’t even cover 30% of the total potential of a patent.”

Ashish Gupta
COO, Evalueserve

The IPR Specialist in India does about 80 per cent of his peer in the US. This is because in India the specialist does not pursue litigation. “We can support the litigation with our research, but we cannot sit with you on the negotiation table,” says Nikhil Sharma. Once Indian courts see more action in the IPR space, we can expect more IPR specialists that can apply their skills in court.

“The thrill is picking up an unstructured problem and then fixing it. The work culture is extremely young and therefore the energy is enormous. Two hours of brainstorming in a room with these guys is quite a high. Other than that we interact with people dealing in R&D for over 20 years, CFOs and CTOs, and so the level of interaction is at another level all together,” he says, illustrating the high points of the job.

Skill sets

An IPR specialist needs a degree in science or engineering and then supplement this with a degree in law. Considering that IPR management covers a number of industries, specialists from/for each industry is required. If the professional is moving laterally from, let’s say, being a telecom engineer and into IPR Management of telecom technologies, then he comes with a certain amount of skill sets already. From here he would have to gain the legal acumen to understand how to apply his skills in IPR Management.

A fresher from an engineering college on the other hand can join a firm and gain the skills in house. Training of a fresher usually takes two to three years.

Impact of background

The brand of your graduate or PG college helps only initially. After about two years this disparity disappears and growth is based purely on performance. A thorough knowledge of a technology field will always be preferred to high scores in tests. Experience gained on the first jobs in specific domains, like telecom or biotechnology, can be applied in the respective fields within IPR management.

An employer's perspective

Evalueserve, among other things, works in IPR. They have a team of 250 people that work in this division. Ashish Gupta, the COO draws on the analogy of real-estate to describe the value of IPR. He points out how the number of patents filed in India has grown nearly ten-fold as compared to four years ago. He looks over to the Chinese and looks at how they filed away 450,000 patents last year, while the US filed away 400,000. The number of patents being filed in the US is growing at a rate of 6-7 per cent, while the number in India is projected to grow by 15 per cent this year. He also points out the

Basic skill sets are:

- Deep domain knowledge
A base of deep domain knowledge is needed to even start thinking in this direction. Science background with law expertise are preferred.
- A constant desire to learn
This is the driver for an IPR specialist
- Researching
There is a large amount of research that is required to ensure that the process or product being patented is unique.
- Strong communication skills
There is a large amount of team interaction that is required.
- Knowledge of the legalities involved
At the end of the day, this is a legal matter.
- Command of the English language
As documents have to be written in the legal language, the exact usage of words is of utmost importance.